

Auwa Book

Last Updated: 5 August 2026

THE BOOKS ARE NOW THE FOUNDATION (5 August 2026)

The three-pillar pivot changed this pillar's status more than any other. The app is parked; Auwa is a character IP business with a Japan practice attached; and **everything downstream — the figure, the collaboration editions, the exhibition route, eventual licensing — depends on the character becoming known**. Publishing these books properly is therefore the single highest-leverage act available to Auwa, and it outranks almost everything else on the to-do list.

Which reweights the publisher question. When the app was the flagship, self-publishing was fine, because the character only had to serve app users. It no longer is. A publisher offers bookshop distribution, foreign rights and review coverage that cannot be bought at any price, and those are precisely the levers on making a character known. **Try the publisher route properly first**, with Colin Midson's view as the decisive input. Set a decision date so it can't drift open-endedly. IngramSpark POD plus a pre-order-funded signed first edition remains the always-available fallback and requires nobody's permission.

Releasing Books 1 and 2 as a set is now more important than ever: two books read as a *series*, which is a materially stronger proposition to a publisher, to press, and to a Japanese maker opening a parcel.

Second job these books do. The printed book is the physical calling card for Japan. Craftsman outreach is gated on it existing, because a maker who has spent forty years on one craft will take a beautiful printed book seriously and a website link not at all. What goes in the parcel: both books, a figure, and a one-page Japanese profile of Auwa and of Rieko as its creator.

See `context/business/business.md` 6.4 and 6.2a, and `CLAUDE.md` → THE PIVOT.

STATUS SNAPSHOT (15 July 2026)

Books 1 and 2 are **both finished, revised, and at print test**. Decision made to **release them together as a set**, not Book 1 alone. Latest print-ready PDFs live in [Dropbox/3 venture/auwa/production/book/Indesign/_indesign/_pdf/_pdf_pages/](#) :

- [AUWA01_8x10.pdf](#) — Book 1, 44 pages
- [AUWA02_8x10.pdf](#) — Book 2, **46 pages (preferred final version)**
- [AUWA02.1_8x10.pdf](#) — Book 2, 44 pages (print-test-only version; the test printer only outputs in multiples of 4, so 46 wasn't available for the test run — this is a test constraint, not the final choice)

Rieko is applying the July feedback amends now. She kept the repeated "we are all connected" message in Reco's speech deliberately (see EDITORIAL FEEDBACK below). Once print test is satisfactory: decide printer/route (KDP vs IngramSpark POD vs approaching publishers) and send both PDFs to Colin Midson (book PR, worked with Tom on his mother's book; was sent Book 1 earlier, no reply yet — the two-book set is a stronger follow-up).

THE FOUR BOOKS

The Auwa illustrated story universe comprises four books, each following Auwa — a luminous being sent from the stars — as it encounters different aspects of Earth and reveals the Kokoro (heart/soul) hidden within all things.

Book 1: The Beginning — Auwa arrives on Earth, finds a lonely blue flower (Bluu) in a dying forest, reveals her Kokoro through a light shower, restores the forest, and meets the soil microbes who explain that everything is connected. *Status: Complete, further revised, at print test. 44 pages, ~470 words. PDF: [_pdf_pages/AUWA01_8x10.pdf](#). Mockup: [/book/1](#) on the website.*

Book 2: Umi (The Ocean) — Auwa explores the ocean, meets a red fish, a yellow coral, and Rai (turtle), cuts loose a drifting ghost net, reaches the Coral Paradise, meets Reco (ancient red coral) and Amo (great whale with her calf Yuki), and hears the sea creatures' stories of humans ("They can be kind" / "They can be cruel" / "We do not understand them yet"). Ends pointing to the human world. *Status: **COMPLETE and fully revised** (was the old 30-page version needing work). ~540 words, 46 pages preferred. PDF: [_pdf_pages/AUWA02_8x10.pdf](#). Mockup: [/book/2](#) on the website.*

Assessment (July 2026): Book 2 is the stronger book and its revision is a textbook execution of the Book 1 template — no speech bubbles, named minor characters culled, the pollution

lecture gone, the ghost net as a wordless visual event. It adds genuine stakes (the human question) and a series engine (Book 3 is now loaded as "the humans" book: land → sea → humans). Releasing the two together turns "a book" into "a series", which is a stronger commercial and PR proposition and lets the two tonal poles (cosmic/dark, aquatic/luminous) show the universe's range.

Book 3: [TBC] — *Status: Not yet reviewed. Book 2's ending sets it up as the humans book.*

Book 4: [TBC] — *Status: Not yet reviewed.*

WHAT THE REVISION ACHIEVES

Book 1 Transformation (the template for all revisions)

The old Book 1 was 30 pages with ~1,200 words. The revised Book 1 is 18 pages with ~380 words. The word count dropped by two-thirds. The emotional impact increased dramatically.

Reference files: Compare `book/1/Auwa_01_0ld.pdf` (old, 30 pages) with `book/1/Auwa01_8x10_Compressed.pdf` (revised, 18 pages) to see the transformation in full. The old version has speech bubbles, over-explained narration, and a 7-spread microorganism taxonomy. The new version is tight, atmospheric, and lets the illustrations carry the story.

What was cut:

- Speech bubbles replaced with narration or sparse italicised dialogue
- WAWA planet dialogue (3 spreads of "Did you feel that signal?" chatter → 1 spread)
- Auwa-Earth pleasantries (3 spreads → 1 spread with a single line from Earth)
- Auwa referring to itself in third person ("Auwa is going to Earth!!" → "I'm going to Earth!")
- Microorganism section (7 spreads of exposition → 2 spreads of philosophy)
- The "five kinds of microorganisms" educational taxonomy (cut entirely)
- Copy that described what the illustration already showed

What was kept/strengthened:

- The emotional arc: wonder → arrival → discovery → connection → restoration → deeper truth → onwards
- Bluu's single devastating line: "I feel so lonely"

- The Yaoyorozu no Kami message: "We are all connected, though you cannot see it"
- Key narrative beats that earn their place
- The song lyrics (condensed but preserved)
- Auwa's farewell into the night sky

EDITORIAL FEEDBACK (July 2026 print-test review)

Claude reviewed both print-ready PDFs against the benchmarks. Both pass the core principles (no speech bubbles, sparse italic dialogue, full-bleed emotional peaks). Both run slightly over the ~350-450 word target (Book 1 ~470, Book 2 ~540), which is fine per the "cut what doesn't earn its place, not hit a number" rule. Fixes flagged, all being applied by Rieko EXCEPT the last:

1. **Book 2 set the character's name as "AUWA" (caps) in narration; Book 1 uses "Auwa".** Inconsistent between books and against the brand rule (caps = wordmark only, never prose). Global find-and-replace in Book 2 InDesign. Cover/title-page wordmark treatment unchanged.
2. Book 1 dedication read "for love"; should be "with love" (Book 2 had it right).
3. Book 1, Bluu's thank-you: comma not period before the closing quote.
4. Book 2 dedication spacing ("thesepages") — check InDesign.
5. Terminology: unify "microbes" vs "soil microbes" vs "microorganisms" across the series. Chose **microbes** (warmer, simpler read-aloud).
6. Book 2: "A great turtle is coming for you" reads faintly ominous; "coming to meet you" keeps the whisper. (Rieko's call.)
7. **NOT applied — Rieko's deliberate choice.** Suggested trimming Reco's 61-word speech (the "everything is connected" line). Rieko is keeping the repeated connection message on purpose, to emphasise it to the reader; she confirmed with the book-side Claude that repeating it isn't strange. Accepted — the repetition is intentional reinforcement of the core Yaoyorozu no Kami theme, not accidental bloat.

EDITORIAL PRINCIPLES

These principles apply to all four books. They were established during the Book 1 revision, benchmarked against Matthew Forsythe's *Aggie and the Ghost*, Jon Klassen, and Oliver Jeffers.

Copy restraint

Maximum 2-3 sentences per spread. The old books average 4-6. If a spread has more than 40 words of narration, it's probably too much. The target word count per book is ~350-450 words (Klassen/Forsythe benchmark). That said, not every book needs to land at 18 pages — some stories are naturally longer. The goal is to cut what doesn't earn its place, not to hit an arbitrary page count. If a book needs 22 or 24 pages to tell its story properly, that's fine.

Kill all speech bubbles

The single biggest quality improvement across all books. Rieko's art is painterly, atmospheric, and luminous — hard-edged speech bubbles with dotted borders sit on top of it like UI elements on a watercolour. Every piece of dialogue that matters should be delivered as direct speech within the narration or as standalone italicised text. Bluu saying "I feel so lonely" hits harder as a line of text beneath the image than trapped inside a grey circle.

Show, don't explain

The old copy describes what the images show. The revised copy tells the reader something the image can't — internal feeling, time passing, what a silence sounds like. "Auwa sensed something alive down there" adds to an image of a dark forest. "Auwa descended into the forest" restates it.

Illustrations carry the narrative weight

In Forsythe, the text tells you one thing and the image tells you more. The strongest moments in Auwa work this way already (the colour explosion, the purple sunset). The weakest moments have text restating what the image shows. Cut those restatements.

Dialogue is sparse and character-revealing

Dialogue should reveal character, not move plot mechanics. "Go and see everything for yourself" (Earth's single line) carries more weight than three spreads of pleasantries. Every character gets a voice that sounds different from the narrator's voice — shorter sentences, simpler words, their own personality.

White space and pacing

Alternate between full-bleed image spreads (minimal text) and text-forward pages. This creates breathing room. The emotional peak (Book 1: colour explosion) should be a full-bleed spread with almost no text. The quiet emotional moment (Bluu's loneliness) should have a single line carrying an entire spread.

Cut third-person self-reference in dialogue

Characters should say "I" not their own name. "Yes! I'm going to Earth!" not "Yes! Auwa is going to Earth!!"

Consolidate, don't sequence

If three spreads show the same beat (meeting, greeting, explaining), consolidate to one. The reader doesn't need every step — they need the feeling.

THE BOOK FORMAT

- **Physical size:** 10 x 8 inches landscape (576 x 720 pts in PDF, ratio 4:5 portrait per page)
 - **Target page count:** 16-20 pages per book (the Klassen/Jeffers benchmark is ~32 pages including front/back matter, which equals ~16 spreads)
 - **Digital format:** Snap-scroll viewer on auwa.life at /book/1, /book/2, etc. Each page fills the viewport. Scroll to advance.
 - **Author credit:** Eko Maeda (Rieko's pen name)
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LAYOUT PATTERNS

Each page in the book uses one of these patterns:

Full-bleed with text overlay — Illustration fills the entire page. Text sits on top, usually bottom-left or bottom-centre, with shadow for readability. Used for panoramic scenes (galaxy, sunset, forest, flower field).

Image beside text (split page) — Illustration on one half, text on the other (usually cream/white background for text). Used for dialogue-heavy scenes and character introductions.

Full-bleed dark — Dark atmospheric illustration fills the page with text in light colour. Used for emotional/atmospheric moments (loneliness, night scenes).

Centred minimal — Mostly negative space with a single line of text. Used for key emotional beats ("I feel so lonely").

THE REVISION PROCESS

For each book, the workflow is:

1. **PDF review** — Read the old version, identify the emotional arc, flag what to cut/keep/strengthen
2. **Mockup build** — Render PDF pages as images, create snap-scroll viewer at /book/N on the website
3. **Rieko review** — Rieko scrolls through the mockup, requests copy tweaks and image changes via Claude Code
4. **Iterate** — Claude applies text overlays for copy changes, swaps images, Rieko reviews again
5. **Lock** — Once happy, Rieko updates the final version in InDesign for print

Text changes in the mockup are applied as HTML overlays positioned on top of the page images. Image swaps are done by replacing the page-XX.jpg files. This gives immediate visual feedback without needing to rebuild in InDesign during the review phase.

BOOK 2 SPECIFIC NOTES (PRE-REVISION)

Book 2 (Umi/Ocean) has the same structural issues as old Book 1, likely amplified:

- **Heavy speech bubble dialogue** throughout — multiple characters (Key, Lady, Rai, Reco, Amo) all introduced through speech bubble exchanges
- **Exposition-heavy** — characters explain ocean pollution, coral bleaching, plastic nets in dialogue. This is the educational tendency that needs to become philosophical.
- **Too many characters introduced too fast** — Key, Lady, Rai appear in rapid succession with formal introductions
- **Environmental messaging is didactic** — "These strange objects began appearing in the sea" / "many problems for us and for the ocean's environment" reads like a report, not a story
- **The emotional arc is buried** — the real story is: Auwa explores, finds beauty damaged, restores it, encounters deeper wisdom about connection. The pollution lecture obscures this.
- **The dolphin memory sequence** (pages ~24-26) is actually interesting but buried under too much surrounding exposition
- **Amo the whale** is the strongest emotional presence but arrives too late and gets too little space

- **The book is 30 pages** — target is ~18 pages (matching Book 1)
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CROSS-BOOK CONTINUITY

- The microorganisms from Book 1 reappear in Book 2 (Reco says "the soil microorganisms told us about you")
- Each book ends with Auwa setting off on the next adventure
- The Kokoro/light shower mechanic is consistent across all books
- Eko Maeda is the author credit on all books
- The "everything is connected" philosophy deepens with each book: land (Book 1) → sea (Book 2) → [TBC] (Book 3) → [TBC] (Book 4)